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The Local Politics of Border Hardening: Transnationality, Resistance, and Accommodation

Jeffrey Coltman-Cormier*
Rutgers University, USA

States are increasingly hardening borders. Scholars have uncovered various causes and effects of this phenomenon, but local reactions to it are less understood. This study takes up the challenge of theorizing borderlands as unique geopolitical spaces in order to explain why the communities therein sometimes resist hardening. Borderland communities that are highly transnational are more likely to have both the inclination and the capacity to mobilize against new restrictions. Yet, when a hardening strategy is designed in ways that meaningfully preserve interaction and exchange across borders, resistance is less likely. This theory is both tested and developed via a mixed-methods design leveraging the COVID-19 pandemic during which most states closed borders. Global quantitative analysis finds that an original geospatial measure of transnationality predicts local protest and riot events against closures. Interviews in two U.S. communities near the border with Mexico, which are highly transnational but did not demonstrate against the closure, show that the policy's accommodation of key flows alleviated the negative impact. Such selective bordering, narrow in its targets, reduces discontent. The findings of this study highlight domestic conflict in international border politics, showing that local communities are focal actors that deserve more attention.

Los Estados están reforzando cada vez más sus fronteras. Los investigadores han descubierto diversas causas y efectos de este fenómeno. Sin embargo, las reacciones por parte de los ciudadanos locales con referencia a este fenómeno son menos conocidas. Este estudio aborda el reto de teorizar sobre las zonas fronterizas como espacios geopolíticos únicos, con el fin de explicar por qué las comunidades que las habitan a veces se resisten a su refuerzo. Las comunidades fronterizas que cuentan con un alto grado de transnacionalidad tienen más probabilidades de tener tanto el deseo como la capacidad de movilizarse contra las nuevas restricciones. Sin embargo, cuando una estrategia de refuerzo se diseña de manera que preserve, de forma significativa, la interacción y el intercambio transfronterizo, resulta menos probable que se produzca esta resistencia. Esta teoría se pone a prueba y se desarrolla mediante un diseño de métodos mixtos que utiliza la pandemia de COVID-19, durante la cual la mayoría de los Estados cerraron sus fronteras. Llevamos a cabo un análisis cuantitativo global que revela que existe una medida geoespacial original en materia de transnacionalidad que predice protestas y disturbios locales contra los cierres. Entrevistas realizadas en dos comunidades estadounidenses cercanas a la frontera con México, que son altamente transnacionales pero que no se manifestaron contra el cierre, muestran que la adaptación de la política a los flujos migratorios clave mitigó el impacto negativo. Este tipo de <<fronterización>> selectiva, con objetivos limitados, reduce el nivel de descontento. Los resultados de este estudio ponen de relieve el conflicto interno que existe en la política fronteriza internacional y demuestra que las comunidades locales son actores fundamentales que merecen un mayor nivel de atención.

Les États renforcent de plus en plus leurs frontières. Les chercheurs ont découvert plusieurs causes et effets de ce phénomène, mais les réactions locales à celui-ci restent mystérieuses. Cette étude relève le défi de théorisation des régions limitrophes comme des espaces géopolitiques uniques afin d'expliquer pourquoi les communautés qui y vivent résistent parfois au renforcement des frontières. Les communautés des régions limitrophes qui sont très transnationales ont plus de chances d'avoir l'inclination comme la capacité de se mobiliser contre de nouvelles restrictions. Pourtant, quand une stratégie de renforcement est conçue de façon à préserver de manière significative les interactions et les échanges transfrontaliers, la probabilité d'une résistance faiblit. L'on teste et développe cette théorie à l'aide d'une conception aux méthodes mixtes s'appuyant sur la pandémie de Covid-19, pendant laquelle la plupart des États ont fermé leurs frontières. D'après l'analyse quantitative mondiale, une mesure géospatiale originale de la transnationalité permet de prédire localement les manifestations et émeutes contre les fermetures de frontières. Des entretiens avec deux communautés états-uniennes près de la frontière avec le Mexique, qui sont très transnationales mais qui n'ont pas manifesté contre la fermeture de la frontière, montrent que la prise en compte de flux clés par la politique atténue les conséquences négatives. Cette création de frontières sélectives, qui discriminent les cibles, réduit le mécontentement. Les conclusions de cette étude mettent en lumière le conflit national dans la politique frontalière internationale, en montrant que les communautés locales sont des acteurs centraux qui méritent plus d'attention.

Introduction

International border politics is transforming. States are building infrastructures like walls and reshaping sovereignty by co-governing with neighbors (Diener and Hagen 2012; Longo 2017). Discourse identifying threats at borders defines populism and the backlash against globalization (Simmons and Goemans 2021; Simmons and Shaffer 2024). Given these normative stakes, scholars have devoted substantial attention to border hardening. This literature has advanced from documenting the hardening trend toward explaining why it occurs (Andreas 2010; Avdan 2018; Carter and Poast 2017; Hassner and Wittenberg 2015; Linebarger and Braithwaite 2022; Simmons and Kenwick 2022) and unpacking whether and how it impacts cross-border flows (Avdan and Gelpi

*Corresponding author: Rutgers University, USA. Email: jjc468@scarletmail.rutgers.edu

Jeffrey Coltman-Cormier is a Doctoral Candidate in the Department of Political Science at Rutgers University. He studies the intersection of borders, human security, and state-building in international politics.

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2017; Carter and Poast 2020; Carter, Donahue, and Williams 2024; Getmansky, Grossman, and Wright 2019; Kim and Tajima 2022; Linebarger and Braithwaite 2020; Rosenberg and Avdan 2025; Schon and Leblang 2021).

This research is crucial for understanding the perennial challenge of facilitating beneficial flows while limiting harmful ones. However, it tells us little about border politics "on-the-ground." Aside from scattered studies (Blair 2025; Cortina 2020; Dainty and Lappe 2026; Gavrilis 2008; Gravelle 2018; Whitaker 2023), the position of border communities on global hardening is unclear. Yet local engagement is often striking. For example, local opposition to hardening has emerged in Finland against its 2023 partial closure of the border with Russia (Harazim 2023), among Indian communities along the borders with Myanmar and Bangladesh (Majumdar 2020), and in Argentina over a fence at the border with Paraguay (Andolina 2020). In contrast, demands for hardening are found in increasingly right-wing Swiss border communities (Alrababah et al. 2025), protests and vigilantism by South African communities near Mozambique (Matlala 2018), and Greek community participation in hardening at the Turkey border (Tagle 2022). These events illustrate variety in local demands, which can include opposition to the generally popular hardening trend. The knowledge deficit on these dynamics is striking given that 1.8 billion people (23% of the human population) live within 50 miles of land borders.[1]

To explain contestation, this study investigates, *why do some local borderland communities resist border hardening by the state?* The bottom-up story outlines when local interests will clash with state prerogatives and morph into collective action. Transnationality is the theoretical focus. Border hardening is salient for communities whose way of life revolves around interaction and exchange across borders. Such communities are incentivized and have the tools to overcome collective action problems and challenge the state, even over hardening that is nationally popular. Yet, the more that hardening accommodates transnationality, the less likely conflict is to emerge. Such selective bordering shows that states can meaningfully redesign their policies in ways that mitigate the local impact.

I evaluate and develop this theory with a mixed-methods design leveraging the COVID-19 pandemic context. Virtually all states with land borders closed them during the pandemic, providing an opportunity to compare local reactions to a comparatively exogenous and "apolitical" form of hardening. The first design component is a deductive global quantitative analysis of transnationality, captured with an original geospatial measure, and hand-coded secondary events data. The key finding is that transnationality predicts local protests and riots against border closures.

The second design component is case studies of two United States (U.S.) communities that are highly transnational but did not resist pandemic border hardening. Studying such "deviant cases" (Levy 2008), or "off-the-line" observations (Lieberman 2005), enables inductive theoretical refinement. Fieldwork interviews with stakeholders in these settings indicate that the closure's impact was diminished because it made exceptions for key flows, undermining widespread and early collective action.

This study makes four contributions. The first is providing a theory for the border politics literature that explains local opposition to hardening. The second contribution is to spotlight the under-recognized tension between some local communities and state priorities. Hardening seen by national publics as a means of protection and security may be experienced by local populations as a fundamental threat. Thus, the proliferation of hardening should be understood as a point of tension not only with the liberal international order (Simmons and Goemans 2021) but with some populations in domestic politics. Third, addressing how to navigate that clash, I develop the concept of selective bordering to specify how variation within border hardening conditions the local impact. Finally, this study provides new and granular global data on cross-border ties while demonstrating the value of using qualitative data to inductively refine theory.

In what follows, I outline the concept of transnationality before linking it to resistance against border hardening. This is followed by the two empirical analyses and the theoretical refinement of selective bordering. The conclusion then outlines broader implications.

Deductive Theory

Conceptualizing Transnationality

The theoretical framework treats borderlands as unique geopolitical spaces and the communities therein as central protagonists. Answering the call to better specify border effects (Braun and Kienitz 2022), I conceptualize how life in borderlands varies. This effort emphasizes transnationality, defined as *the extent to which a borderland community is connected to society across the border*.[2] The concept focuses on communities in the areas both proximate to and bisected by an international land border. A borderland encompasses two national spaces, although nearby borderlands do occasionally overlap.

The distinctiveness of borderlands, relative to country interiors, is physical proximity to a border. Proximity affects communities in diverse ways (Braun and Kienitz 2022; Idler 2019). In one sense, proximity can have negative implications in the form of insecurity. Borders may enable and attract criminals and insurgents engaging in violence or evading states. Relatedly, border areas may be the target of state repression.

Yet proximity can also generate beneficial opportunities for local populations to interact and exchange with people and institutions across borders. People outside of borderlands can travel, digitally communicate across borders, and consume international goods. But proximity enables deeper ties embedded in day-to-day life and personal experiences (Mirwaldt 2010).

Transnationality consists of two dimensions. The economic dimension encompasses formal and informal trade, smuggling, work, shopping, and transhumant pastoral systems; the social dimension encompasses familial, ethnic, religious, and other interpersonal linkages. The two dimensions are not intrinsically bundled, and individuals within a given community may differ in their levels of cross-border engagement.

The extent to which transnationality characterizes communities varies both within and across borderlands (Wilson and Donnan 1998). For example, high transnationality characterizes many communities in the U.S.–Mexico borderland in the forms of work, school, commerce, medical care, and friends and kin, as well as illicit flows (Díaz-Barriga and Dorsey 2020; Martínez 1994). Many residents articulate an inter-connected identity (Dear 2020; Stea, Zech, and Gray 2010). Conversely, communities on the Botswana

[1] This calculation uses global LandScan population data (Sims et al. 2022) and the borders data in this study.

[2] This definition differs from that used in migration studies, which emphasizes migrants' long-term ties with home countries (Levitt and Jaworsky 2007).

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side of the Botswana–Zimbabwe borderland generally exemplify low transnationality. Although Kalanga people live on both sides of this sparsely populated borderland (The New Humanitarian 2005), most movement across this border is transitory and one-sided in the form of Zimbabweans migrating to the interior of Botswana for work and security. Xenophobia is widespread throughout Botswana, including in the border region (Campbell and Crush 2015).

Transnationality is enduring but evolves over time. The diversity of forces that shape it underscores that transnationality is distinct from other forms of exchange and interaction across borders. On the one hand, states can influence the long-term trajectory of transnationality. This includes violently manipulating borderland demographics to eliminate the ethnic basis of social ties (McNamee and Zhang 2019; Müller-Crepon, Schvitz, and Cederman 2025). Yet, states can also contribute to transnationality. For example, roads built to facilitate inter-country trade indirectly enable local populations to participate in cross-border economies, as has happened with the North American Free Trade Agreement (Stea, Zech, and Gray 2010). State intervention may also follow entrenched practices, such as attempts to formalize smuggling flows (Su 2022).

As for bottom-up forces, local actors can use their agency to shape transnationality. They can work to foster trade and binational governance institutions to stimulate development and cooperation (Gallien 2020; Markusse 2011; Matanzima, Helliker, and Pophiwa 2023; Miggelbrink 2014). People in borderlands may also act to sustain social linkages, especially for minority ethnic groups whose existence predates colonial-era borders (Ghosh 2011; Moyo 2016).

Overall, transnationality is a dynamic yet enduring trait. Borderland communities vary in the degree and form of their cross-border ties over space and time. These shape the local politics of border hardening.

Resistance against Border Hardening

The theory uses transnationality to explain how borderland communities, the primary unit of analysis, engage with border hardening. While classic scholarship highlights community agency in demanding the consolidation of borders (Sahlins 1989), I focus on why communities would oppose otherwise popular hardening, as well as what states can do to mitigate conflict. The argument is that transnationality shapes interests and collective action processes. Highly transnational communities broadly favor the status quo. In turn, they are more likely than other borderland communities to perceive hardening as a disruptive threat. Community traits associated with transnationality enable them to overcome the collective action problem and mobilize. Extant theories miss these dynamics, homogenizing national public support for border hardening as driven by a shared sense of threat.

Transnationality and Interests

I draw from the Baud and van Schendel (1997) model of borderland–state relations to situate the community as the focal unit of analysis. Communities further contain local and regional elites as well as a potentially heterogeneous public. The other key actor is the central state seeking to harden the border.

The regular interaction and exchange across borders associated with transnationality poses important implications for the prevailing interests in communities. This occurs along the two dimensions. First, in economic terms, interaction and exchange create dependency on the status quo. These activities structure the local economy for citizens, firms, and elites, who become dependent on the revenue and thus develop a preference for policies that sustain this revenue. This logic follows work finding that people in areas benefiting from economic openness have a different orientation toward trade policy than people in areas harmed by import competition (e.g., Jensen, Quinn, and Weymouth 2017).

The second implication of transnationality is positive social sentiment. Contact with people across borders can fuel positive perceptions of outgroups (Mirwaldt 2010) and increase support for fighting human rights abuses abroad (Pauselli 2025). I consider these effects through the lens of contact theory. The framework posits that contact between groups under certain conditions engenders positive sentiment. The interaction and exchange embedded in transnationality connote the four conditions: equal status between the cross-border groups, shared goals, cooperation between these groups, and support in the local institutional context and customs (Allport 1954, 281; see also Paluck, Green, and Green 2019).

Relatedly, people in highly transnational communities often develop a sense of cross-border belonging. Although the printing press and modern maps have propagated national and territorial conceptions of polities (Anderson 2006; Branch 2014), living in a highly transnational community engenders more cohesive social worlds (Dear 2020; Ghosh 2011; Idler 2019; Mirwaldt 2010). People in such settings often recognize complex, cross-cutting identities.

The Threat of Border Hardening

Given how transnationality shapes community interests, the potential clash with border hardening is straightforward. The more transnational a borderland community, the greater the swathe of the public and elites who have an interest in policies that sustain contextually relevant interaction and exchange. New hardening that targets these activities is likely to be seen as a threat to the status quo. The fear is that established patterns of interaction and exchange will be obstructed.

In terms of economic ties, the economic revenue generated from cross-border mobility may be lost. The concern is that border hardening will decrease formal trade, informal trade, and/or smuggling flows by slowing down or entirely inhibiting traffic across the border (Blair 2024; Carter and Poast 2020). This would threaten livelihoods and the provision of goods.

As for social ties, the fear is of limitations to communication across borders. This applies to ties built around family, friends, ethnicity, religion, and more. Nationally oriented border hardening is seen as imposing an inflexible identity over local, potentially more fluid, conceptions (Cortina 2020; Dear 2020; Díaz-Barriga and Dorsey 2020).

For this clash to emerge, not all individuals or sub-groups within a transnational community need to directly participate in transnationality. Prior ethnographic work finds that subgroups engage with changing borders differently based on their histories, identities, and practices (e.g., Pfoser 2015). Certain subgroups in a given community may even feel negatively about cross-border interaction and exchange. The inverse is true for low-transnationality communities, which may contain individuals or subgroups that nevertheless feel positively about society across the border. Here, the key point is that transnationality generates vested interests for actors in the community that will manifest in collective behavior. When a sufficient degree of the community's public, elites,

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and sectors perceive a threat, then a clash of interests that can turn into action emerges.

This theory applies across borderlands with varying levels of prior hardening. Transnationality exists among communities encountering different levels of state presence, spanning heavily securitized and militarized sites like U.S. or South African borders as well as areas with little state presence like many segments of the India–Bangladesh border. Moreover, the basis of transnational ties can emerge prior to the initial delineation of borders, as with colonial borders imposed on diverse societies. Thus, new hardening always has the potential to upend the way of life for transnational communities, regardless of prior hardening or lack thereof.

From Clashing Interests to Collective Action

Resistance refers to actions that demand the end or reduced intensity of a border hardening strategy. The exemplary form is social movements in which, drawing on shared purpose and identity, people collectively confront a state via boycotts, petitions, demonstrations, strikes, or legal action (Tarrow 2011). Importantly, resistance does not inevitably emerge out of discontent. Displeasure among a sufficient degree of sub-actors within communities needs to aggregate into behavior. But the coordination of collective action is the classic challenge for human groups. Transnational communities, however, have traits that enable them to overcome these problems. This point applies across the three conditions that are jointly necessary for resistance to emerge: political opportunity, availability of mobilization resources, and framing processes of grievance (McAdam 2017; Tarrow 2011).

To start, political opportunity for mobilization is heightened when a border is in (potential) flux. It is easier to mobilize around imminent change than stagnancy. This is because there is a more meaningful opportunity for communities to shape the evolving outcome.

Second, transnational communities often possess or are capable of generating the resources needed to organize. The formal economic and social organizations involved in cross-border interaction and exchange provide resources to coordinate mobilization and to monitor participation. These include non-governmental organizations, unions, business groups, social organizations, and local government entities. Moreover, political or economic elites whose own interests are threatened or who wish to cultivate local support can lower the costs of resistance by encouraging dissent (Ying 2021), refusing to punish illegal actions (Garfias and Sellars 2022), and directly making demands themselves.

Third, the notion of being a misunderstood and disregarded borderland community provides a frame of reference for grievances (Kajta and Opiłowska 2023). This idea taps into a shared meaning and cultural understanding of incursion from outsiders, creating the sense of grievance and optimism needed to challenge the threat. This framing is especially effective among transnational communities since it links to salient identities (Mulugeta and Wando 2025).

Altogether, the convergence of opportunity, resources, and framing needed for resistance is especially likely for transnational communities facing border hardening. This bundle of traits helps such communities overcome collective action problems and mobilize. The observable implication is as follows:

> **Transnational Resistance Hypothesis:** *The more transnational a borderland community, the more likely it is to resist border hardening.*

I test this deductive expectation in the upcoming empirical analysis, but I follow it with an inductive refinement based on case studies. In brief, the logic is that "selective bordering"—efforts to control borders whose range of targets is scoped—is less likely to spark resistance. If selectivity accounts for local ways of life, more within-community interests associated with transnationality are preserved. Such accommodation preempts conflict by entirely mitigating the impact on transnationality or, in having only a partial impact, by undermining collective action.

Learning from Pandemic Bordering

I test the general theory in the COVID-19 pandemic context. The border closures widely deployed during this time provide two inferential advantages, relative to other forms of hardening. First, the closures provide a "tough" test. They were inherently temporary, in contrast to comparatively enduring structures like walls, guard stations, and surveillance systems. Closures also targeted an "obvious" public health threat in the low-information, fear-ridden environment rather than more overtly politicized movement like immigration (Kenwick and Simmons 2020). In fact, closures received broad national-level support (Chilton et al. 2024; Lindholt et al. 2021). Thus, even transnational communities might be expected to have willingly accepted the temporary costs of closures. If border hardening sparks local opposition, this form should be the least likely to do so. Finding that transnationality drove resistance even against pandemic closures would provide robust evidence that the theory applies more generally, in a logic similar to "least-likely" case selection (Levy 2008).

The second advantage of examining closures is their largely exogenous nature: the sudden threat of virus transmission prompted 89% of states with land borders to enact a closure (Shiraef et al. 2022). This policy was adopted even in the Schengen Area where such acts are rarely seen. Thus, the explanatory factors ascribed to the differential adoption of conventional border hardening approaches do not apply. Assessing the influence of transnationality on resistance against closures is less susceptible to confounding.

Leveraging these features of pandemic border closures, my mixed-method design includes two elements. The first is a global quantitative analysis of transnationality and resistance events testing the deductive **Transnational Resistance Hypothesis**. The second component is a pair of case studies investigating communities that deviated from the theory in order to inductively refine the theory.

Quantitative Evidence

The phenomena of interest are the transnationality of borderland communities and whether they politically resisted border closures during the COVID-19 pandemic. In order to quantitatively evaluate this relationship, I both create a measure of *Transnationality* and hand-code secondary events data.

Measuring Transnationality

My original, cross-sectional, and geospatial measure of transnationality has global coverage. To my knowledge, it is the first measure of spatial variation in cross-border ties that operates at the community-level and that integrates information spanning economic and social forms of connection. The local, society-focused measure complements state-oriented datasets (e.g., Deutschmann, Gabrielli, and Recchi 2023; Kenwick, Simmons, and McAlexander 2024; Kenwick et al. 2025).

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The unit of analysis is the borderland community. The dataset consists of 30 x 30 kilometer (KM) grid cells over all populated landmass areas within 50 miles, or approximately 80 KM, of all 305 international land borders. Each borderline was transformed to a two-sided borderland with the 50-mile buffers, and then each side's shape was rasterized into multiple grid cell communities. The dataset contains 49,056 community cell observations. Treating populated cells as proxies for local communities, each is scored on an additive index for transnationality. It summarizes cells' proximity to a set of items intersecting or reaching across the nearby border: roads, railroads, ethnic kin settlements, and sister cities. Community cells located more closely to these items receive a higher score on the transnationality index, which has twenty-one unique values between 0 and 5 (see the variable's distribution in Online Appendix 1.4).

The transnationality index is designed around significant limitations with global data. The ideal information would be hyper-local and time-varying data on the frequency and direction of all types of flows across all borders. Such data, however, simply does not exist at a global scale. The next best approach is to identify, per community cell, its relative proximity to phenomena that signify transnational connection. Using variation in physical proximity to border-relevant items approximates variation in practiced transnationality. Being located in a borderland does not inherently mean that a community is transnational. However, being closer to a road that is known to reach a border, for example, is a reasonable indication that transnational interaction and exchange is more prevalent. Both roads and railroads are sites of movement, ethnic kin settlements represent areas with plausible social ties, and sister cities establish distinct agreements and practices of cooperation. By contrast, communities that are farther from any of these items are more spatially isolated from cross-border interaction and exchange. Using relative distance, rather than binary "containment" of items, maximizes cell comparability. Relative distance, for example, avoids equating a road-less cell abutting a with-road cell to a cell located much farther away that is very distant from any border-intersecting road. Overall, the measurement strategy disentangles presence in a borderland context into meaningful gradations in cross-border connection strength.

Further detail on the measurement process and the data sources is provided in Online Appendix 1 due to space limitations. But the maps below illustrate the measure with visualizations of the Czechia side of the Czechia–Poland borderland. The maps in Figure 1 represent the first phase. Panel (a) shows how the border is derived from where the two country shapes intersect. In turn, panel (b) depicts the landmass areas within 50 miles becoming the borderland sides. In panel (c), the borderland sides are converted into the 1 KM x 1 KM raster cells originally generated from LandScan population data (Rose et al. 2020), including only cells that contain people.

The second set of maps in Figure 2 depicts the process of adding item-level information to cells aggregated to 30 x 30 KM and converting the distance values into ordinal values that are summarized into the final index. In panel (a), the instances of the items used are shown. In this particular borderland side, roads, railroads and sister cities are present, but ethnic kin settlements are not. Distances to the nearest items are then calculated and converted to the ordinal scale as shown in panel (b), with larger values representing closer proximity and the lowest value being assigned when that item is absent from the borderland side. Finally, panel (c) shows the additive index scores for each community cell, which were constructed by summing the ordinal item values and then dividing by four since there are that many items. The final panel demonstrates the granular variation that the measure provides: the multiple community cells within a given borderland side receive their own transnationality scores.

A series of validity tests presented in Online Appendix 2 provide evidence that the measure meaningfully operationalizes the concept of transnationality (Adcock and Collier 2001). First, each item positively correlates with the index, while the items themselves share weak to near-zero correlations (see Online Appendix 2.1). Each item thus contributes to the index while capturing a distinct facet of transnationality. Second, affirming that Transnationality goes beyond borderland-interior differences to capture between-community variation, Transnationality and distance from the border are weakly correlated ($\rho = -0.13$, see Online Appendix 2.2). Finally, more stringent nomological validity tests detailed in Online Appendices 2.3 and 2.4 provide evidence that the measure behaves as it should in predicting both greater wealth and shorter travel time to border crossings. Altogether, these tests provide evidence for measurement validity.

Measuring Resistance

Resistance is a binary variable indicating whether a community protested or rioted against a closure of the nearby border that was enacted by its own state between 2020 and 2021. The data is sourced from the Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project (ACLED). This widely used source produced the COVID-19 Disorder Tracker, or the subset of all ACLED events specifically related to the pandemic (Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project 2025). The pandemic dataset includes approximately 63,000 geolocated events from 2020 to 2023 accompanied by brief qualitative descriptions. I use the 2020–2021 subset for alignment with the closures data detailed below.

Scholars have found biases in such media-sourced data concerning consistency and constancy of reporting both within and between contexts (Parkinson 2024). However, the ACLED COVID-19 Disorder Tracker has a particular advantage: demand for knowledge about the pandemic was extremely high. ACLED extended data collection to nearly all countries at the time, improving coverage for these particular types of events (see Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project 2026).

To operationalize Resistance, I first used border-related keywords to identify potentially relevant protests and riots.[3] Undergraduate research assistants and I then hand-coded this data to identify which events actually concerned closures and, of those, which events specifically opposed restrictions and what the associated borders were (see the codebook in Online Appendix 6). The qualitative descriptions consistently reflect the distinctly local concerns about closures. For example: "... workers protested in Vinhais, demanding the Portuguese-Spanish border's reopening - closed to coronavirus-related restrictions."

This process identified 457 relevant events from 2020 to 2021. 416 events (91%) occurred within borderlands, and most of these events opposed rather than supported closures (386 events, or 93%). These events' locations are shown in Figure 3.

[3] The regular expressions included "[Bb]order*", "[Bb]oundar*", "[Cc]rossing*", "[Cc]heckpoint*", "[Ii]nternational [Bb]ridge*", and "[Ff]rontier*".

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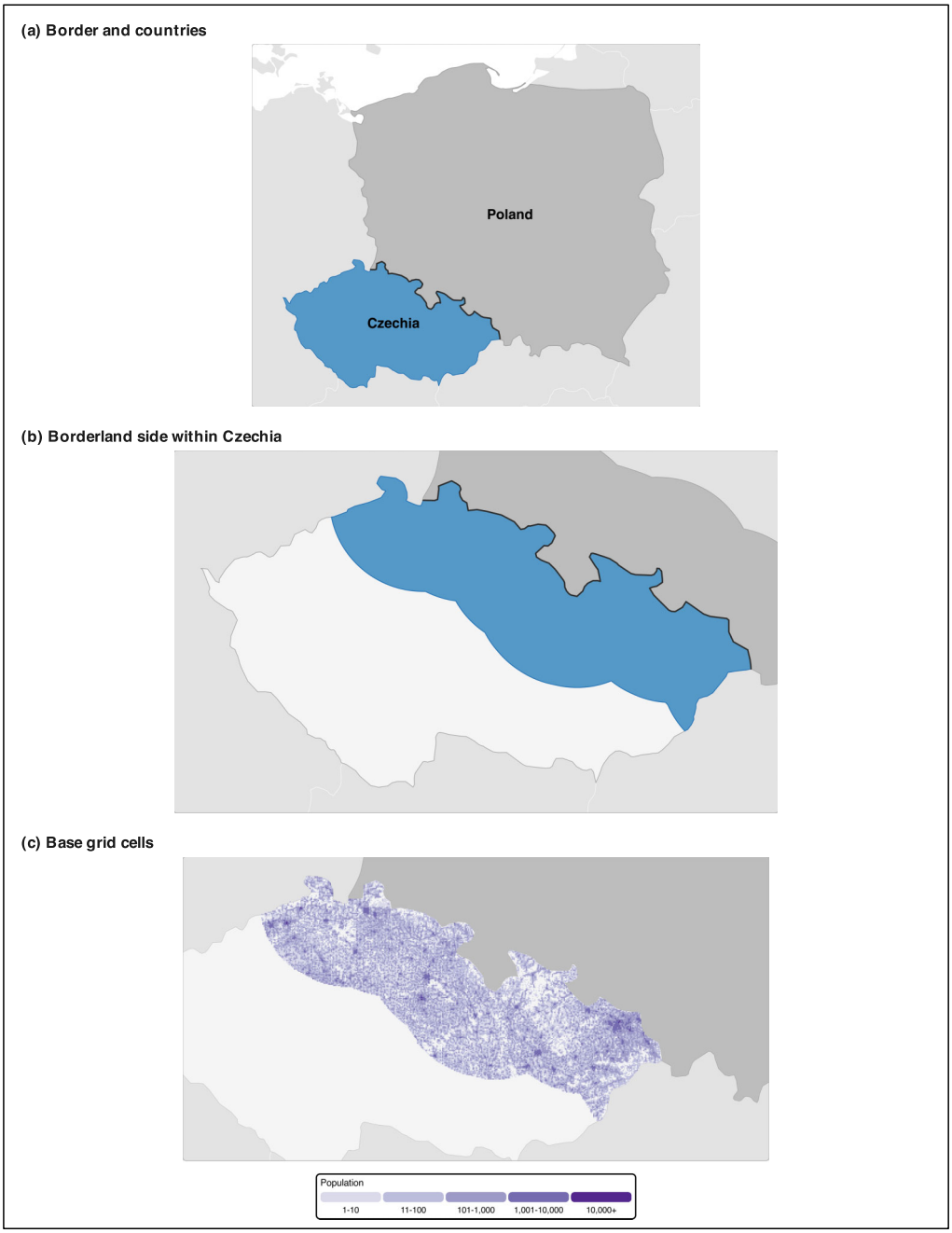


Figure 1 Measurement process example I.

Sample and Models

To ensure theoretical relevance, the sample includes only community grid cells whose country actually enacted a border closure. For the minority of communities not exposed to this policy, there was no closure to potentially resist. Further, while the underlying theoretical logic might explain behavior by any community, the most meaningful chance for resistance was against a community's own state.

The closures data is from the COVID Border Accountability Project, which tracked the number and content of border restrictions from 2020 to 2021 (Shiraef et al. 2022). 135 out of 151 countries with land borders (approximately 89%) enacted a closure at least once during this period. Limiting the sample to community grid cells among these countries reduces the size by about 10% to 43,929 observations. The adoption of closures was unrelated to Transnationality, supporting the idea that this form of hardening was largely exogenous to local conditions related to transnationality.[4]

Using the hand-coded resistance data, each community grid cell is coded for whether at least one event about the associated border transpired within that cell between 2020 and 2021. 121 cells experienced one or more events, indicating that community-level Resistance occurred but was rare. Across all borderland sides exposed to closures, 69 of 526 (13%) experienced any Resistance.

[4] In an aggregated analysis, there is little to no association between the average Transnationality of a borderland side and closures ($\rho = -0.02$), or between the average Transnationality of a country's borderlands and closures ($\rho = -0.1$).

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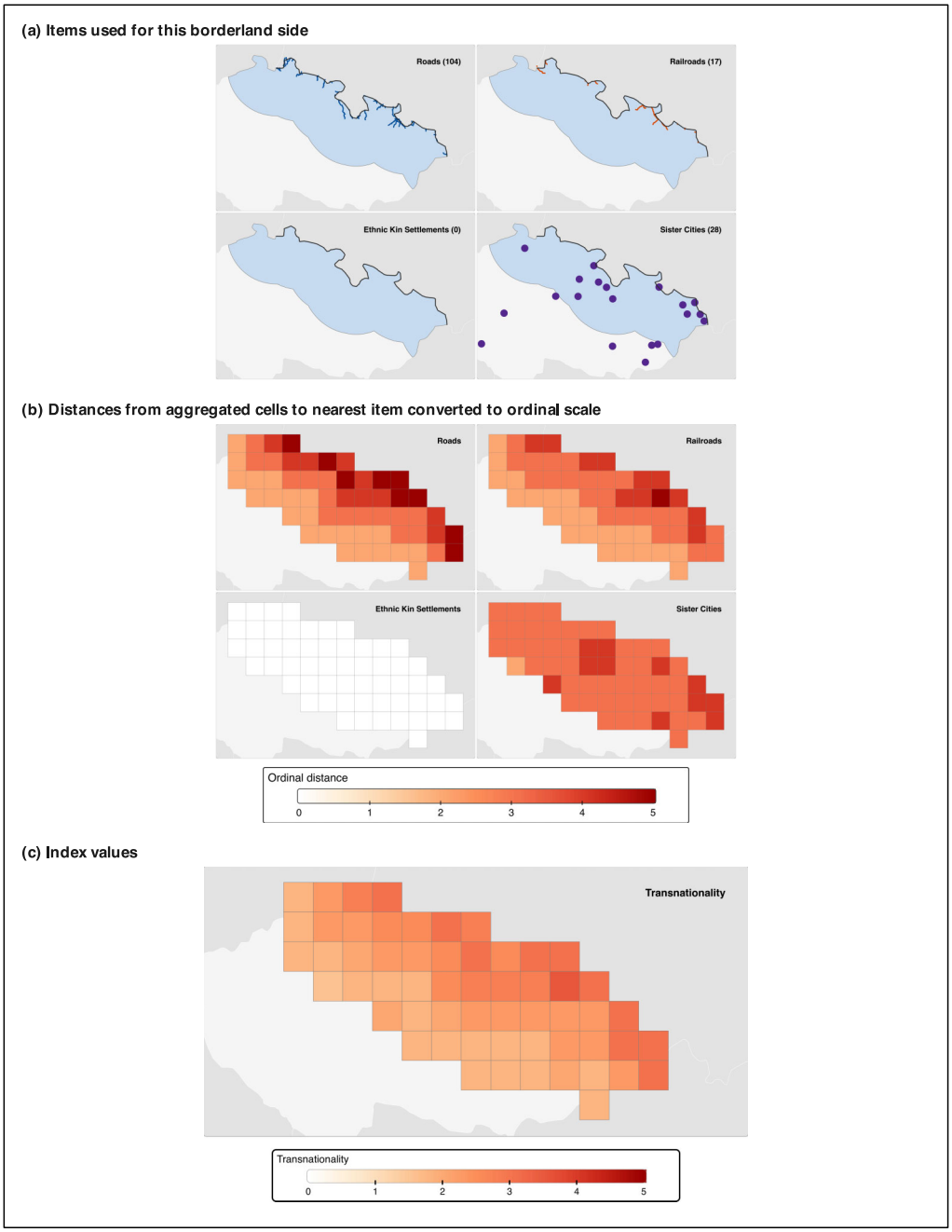


Figure 2 Measurement process example II.

Community-level Resistance is modeled as a function of Transnationality and other variables in logistic regression models. To account for unobserved confounding, models include fixed effects for the borderland side (Models 1–2), overall borderland (Models 3–4), or country (Models 5–6). Each specification is relevant, but the borderland side fixed effects model is the best suited for testing the **Transnational Resistance Hypothesis**. This is because the model uses the most granular unit in comparing communities on the same borderland side but that vary by Transnationality.

To further mitigate potential confounding, all models include a series of control variables. The first is a continuous variable for logged *Population* from the original LandScan raster data (Rose et al. 2020). Recent work linking population size and protest (Dorward and Fox 2022; Thomson et al. 2023) suggests that larger communities may be both more transnational and more capable of protesting due to having more people that could be affected by border policy and able to participate in mobilization. The next control is a dichotomous variable for the presence of *Resources* (Denly et al. 2022), a proxy for communities that have more robust economies and associated institutions to contest the state. The third control is a continuous variable for terrain *Ruggedness* (Shaver, Carter, and Shawa 2019), which has been found to associate with contentious politics.[5] The next

[5]Addressing multicollinearity concerns, Ruggedness does not meaningfully correlate with Transnationality ($\rho = 0.02$) or with the infrastructure items of road connectivity ($\rho = 0.07$) and railroad connectivity ($\rho = 0.00$).

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Figure 3 Resistance map.

control is a continuous variable for logged *Capital Distance* (Schvitz et al. 2022), which proxies the degree of incorporation into the national polity since more incorporated communities might be less susceptible to border-related shocks. Finally, additional specifications account for the potential spatial diffusion of Resistance. This involves adding a binary spatial lag *Adjacent Event* indicating whether at least one resistance event occurred in an adjacent grid cell (Models 2, 4, and 6).

Finally, all of the independent variables are rescaled as advised by Gelman (2008). This entails de-meaning all variables and then, for continuous variables, also dividing by two standard deviations. The advantage of this linear transformation is being able to compare the relative strength of predictors that are originally measured in different units. Rescaling does not change the actual effects or uncertainties estimated. Each coefficient represents the change in the log odds of the outcome when the independent variable, regardless of original scale, increases by two standard deviations. For clarity, equivalent results from models using non-rescaled variables are in Online Appendix 3.

Results

The expectation is that more transnational borderland communities were more likely than other borderland communities to resist border hardening. Overall, the results displayed in Table 1 are consistent with this **Transnational Resistance Hypothesis**. Across all model specifications, Transnationality positively and significantly associates with Resistance. Moreover, the magnitude of the coefficient across the models is the largest or second-largest of all significant effects.

Additionally, the spatial lag models suggest a diffusion process. When comparing communities in the same borderland (Model 4) or in the same country (Model 6), but not the same borderland side (Model 2), Resistance by a neighboring community (Adjacent Event) predicts Resistance by the focal community. This occurs alongside the independent influence of Transnationality, which remains positive and significant in these models.

For a substantive interpretation, Figure 4 displays the predicted probabilities of Resistance at different values of Transnationality.[6] These hold covariates at observed values. Each sub-figure corresponds to one of the models without a spatial lag.

In each plot, moderately and highly transnational communities are meaningfully more likely to contest closures. These shifts are especially notable given the rarity of Resistance. Across models, the predicted probability of Resistance is effectively 0 for low Transnationality, aligning with the base rate of 0.003. However, the estimates clearly exceed the base rate as Transnationality increases, as illustrated by Model 1 with borderland side fixed effects. At the modal Transnationality value of 2 (see Online Appendix 1.4), the predicted probability reaches 0.03 [95% CI: 0.02,0.04]. This probability is low in the absolute but nearly 10 times the base rate. In a starker shift, the predicted probability of Resistance reaches 0.13 [95% CI: 0.1,0.2] when Transnationality is 3, 0.36 [95% CI: 0.3,0.5] when Transnationality is 4, and 0.64 [95% CI: 0.5,0.8] when Transnationality is its max at 5. These estimates signal that increasing Transnationality meaningfully moves the probability of Resistance. Similar estimates emerge from Model 3 with fixed effects for borderlands.

Notably, the probabilities derived from Model 5 with country fixed effects reflect a smaller effect size. As stated above, this specification is the least granular out of the three and the least suited to estimating the locally varying effect of Transnationality between otherwise similar communities. Even so, the substantively meaningful increases exhibited relative to the extremely low base rate of Resistance are consistent with the **Transnational Resistance Hypothesis**. For example, the predicted probability at the modal Transnationality value of 2 reaches 0.006 [95% CI: 0.005,0.007], which is nearly twice the base rate. At maximum Transnationality, the predicted probability of Resistance reaches 0.08 [95% CI: 0.03,0.13], which is 28 times the base rate.

[6] For ease of visual interpretation, the x-axis in these plots shows the original, non-rescaled values of Transnationality (0–5). The curves are identical to the plots using the rescaled values, shown in Online Appendix 3.

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Table 1. Transnationality and resistance against COVID-19 border closures

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Transnationality	4.608*	4.752*	3.982*	3.821*	1.826*	1.694*
	(0.465)	(0.477)	(0.399)	(0.408)	(0.287)	(0.292)
Population (Logged)	4.338*	4.332*	3.746*	3.801*	4.298*	4.285*
	(0.465)	(0.464)	(0.414)	(0.419)	(0.406)	(0.410)
Resources	−0.139	−0.109	0.071	0.036	0.173	0.068
	(0.408)	(0.407)	(0.372)	(0.376)	(0.362)	(0.365)
Ruggedness	−1.107*	−1.142*	−0.574	−0.578	−0.676*	−0.567
	(0.379)	(0.374)	(0.349)	(0.357)	(0.296)	(0.303)
Capital Distance (Logged)	0.751	0.716	−0.290	−0.142	0.625*	0.688*
	(0.438)	(0.434)	(0.267)	(0.276)	(0.290)	(0.297)
Adjacent Event		−0.362		0.675*		0.890*
		(0.270)		(0.234)		(0.243)
n	7805	7805	11204	11204	17596	17596
Borderland Side FEs	✓	✓				
Borderland FEs			✓	✓		
Country FEs					✓	✓

* $p < 0.05$.

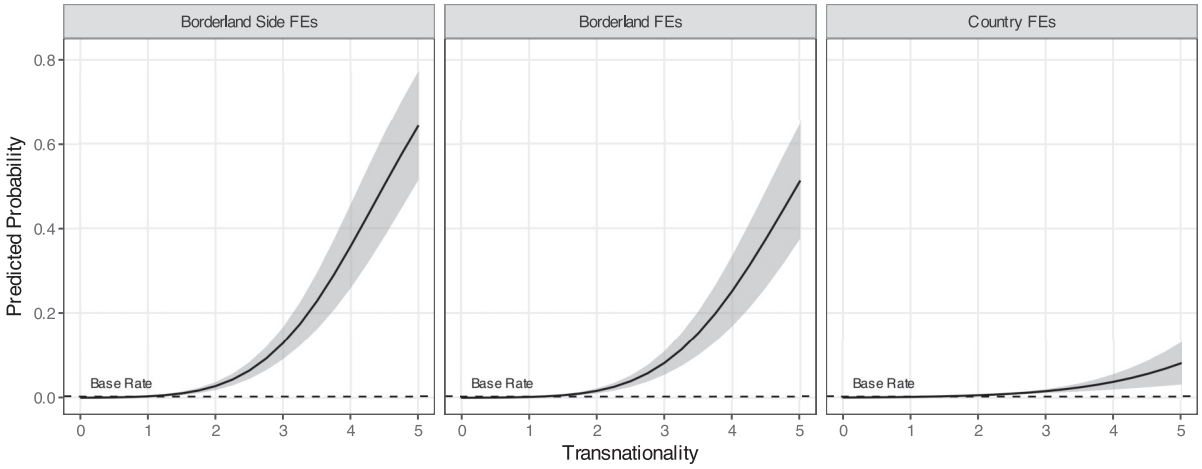


Figure 4 Predicted probability of resistance against COVID-19 border closures.

Robustness Checks and Subgroup Analyses

Overall, in support of the **Transnational Resistance Hypothesis**, Transnationality associates with Resistance against border closures during the COVID-19 pandemic. A series of robustness checks bolsters the evidence. First, Transnationality is not found to predict protests and riots unrelated to border closures during the same time period, ruling out an unobserved confounder driving both Transnationality and a general proclivity to challenge states (see Online Appendix 4.1). Second, when disaggregating the index into the individual items, road and railroad connectivity but not ethnic kin and sister cities associates with Resistance (see Online Appendix 4.2). This finding is consistent with the overall theory but suggests that economic concerns may have played a greater role than social concerns in driving resistance. Third, altering the Transnationality measure with an alternative ordinalization scheme for the underlying items yields the same result (see Online Appendix 4.3). Fourth, the positive finding also holds when using linear probability models that do not drop observations from fixed effects units without variation in Resistance (Timoneda 2021) (see Online Appendix 4.4). Fifth, the modifiable areal unit problem does not appear to bias results since the finding holds in analyses using alternate grid cell sizes (see Online Appendix 4.5). Finally, investigating whether variation in communities' distance to the border drives the Transnationality–Resistance relationship, models that add a control variable for *Border Distance* broadly yield a consistent result (see Online Appendix 4.6).

Online Appendix 5 presents subgroup analyses to explore potential scope conditions. First, the positive Transnationality–Resistance relationship holds among communities in borderlands both with and without walls (see Online Appendix 5.1). This result is consistent with the earlier claim that the theory explains resistance across contexts with varying policy histories. Second, Transnationality continues to predict Resistance to border closures among subsamples differentiated by state capacity (see Online Appendix 5.2). Finally, regime type does not moderate the relationship, which still holds in both democracies and autocracies (see Online Appendix 5.3).

Overall, the consistent result underscores the centrality of transnationality to local resistance against COVID-19 border closures. In the absence of meaningful transnational ties,

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resistance essentially never took place. Transnationality was a key factor driving the resistance that transpired.

Qualitative Evidence

The quantitative analysis indicates that more transnational communities were more likely to resist COVID-19 border closures. However, exceptions defy the pattern. For example, the U.S. closed the border with Mexico for nearly two years (Department of Homeland Security 2020; Federal Register 2021), yet none of the highly transnational communities throughout the region protested or rioted.

These outliers suggest limits to the theory. Why would border hardening not produce conflict? I investigate this anomaly with evidence gathered within communities. Investigating "deviant cases" (Levy 2008) or "off-the-line" observations (Lieberman 2005) is an established practice for inductively refining theory.

Cases

I examine Nogales and San Luis in Arizona, two small cities on the border with Mexico (see Figure 5), as my deviant cases. Two external validity considerations are particularly noteworthy here (see Gerring 2017). First, they should be treated as representative specifically of extremely transnational communities. This point corresponds to the established assessment of scholars (Romo and Márquez 2010; Stea, Zech, and Gray 2010) and to my quantitative measure, which scores both Nogales and San Luis at 3.75 (98th percentile).

Second, these communities should be treated as representative of democratic contexts in which protest is comparatively feasible. Although democracies on the whole have less hardened borders than autocracies (Simmons and Kenwick 2022), the actions of many states like the U.S., South Africa, and those at the edge of the European Union show that the trend toward hardening involves states of all regime types. The cases most clearly speak to this type of context.

Interviewee Sampling

To access the perspectives and knowledge of local stakeholders, I conducted semi-structured interviews during a 3-week fieldwork trip across Nogales, San Luis, and the surrounding area in October–November 2024. The appropriate sampling strategy was a mix of purposive and snowball sampling, sometimes with the assistance of an interlocutor at a lobbying firm, for individuals in public and private sectors with knowledge about border issues (Kapiszewski, MacLean, and Read 2015).[7] This sampling process yielded eighteen interviews across Nogales and San Luis, as well as Yuma (see Table 2). Most interviewees worked in local government, while others were members of the local port authorities, business owners, and activists involved in humanitarian work.

In the semi-structured interviews, I asked open-ended questions from questionnaires (see Online Appendix 7). This approach generated comparable data across interviews while permitting unexpected topics. See Online Appendix 8 for ethical considerations.

Table 2. Interview data sample

Category	Number
Mayor	2
City Administration	2
City Council	1
Port Authority Member	6
County Supervisor	2
State Agency	1
State Congressperson (Former)	1
Businessperson	5
Activist	3

Note: Some individuals in the eighteen-person sample overlap multiple categories.

Case Study Findings

First, it is confirmed that Nogales and San Luis are highly transnational. Second, interviewees recounted decades of political efficacy advocating for ports of entry, which makes the lack of mobilization against the pandemic closure more perplexing. Third, the closure made exceptions for a substantial breadth of movement, largely sustaining the borderland economy. Yet, fourth, leaders made public criticisms about the harm to downtown storefronts more than a year into the closure. This constituted a narrow form of opposition whose late emergence reflects the limitations of collective action in the face of a broadly accommodating border closure.

After presenting these findings, I advance the concept of selective bordering. The more narrow the set of actors and flows a hardening strategy targets, the more selective it is. Selective bordering imposes fewer costs on key actors in transnational communities. This entirely forestalls a clash of interests or, if affecting only a narrow slice of interests, undermines collective action. Thus, state accommodations can reduce conflict with transnational borderland communities.

Finding 1: Confirming Transnationality

The manner in which every interviewee characterized local life reflects the concept of transnationality, confirming the case selection premise. They chronicled deep and long-lasting cross-border ties throughout history. Nogales first emerged in the area that became part of the U.S. via the 1853 Gadsden Purchase from Mexico after a pair of Russian-Jewish immigrants opened a trading post in 1880. The first border rail crossing opened there in 1882, heralding the growth of Nogales as a city. San Luis was founded later in 1930 alongside a port of entry and was eventually incorporated in 1979 after an explosion of border-related economic growth. Today, Nogales and San Luis number approximately 20,000 and 40,000, respectively. They neighbor the larger cities of Nogales and San Luis Río Colorado in Sonora, Mexico. Both are majority-Hispanic and historically lean Democratic.

The centrality of transnationality to local life is exemplified by a long-time city government employee and official in Nogales remarking that "We live, die, and breathe everything associated with the border."[8] On the economic dimension, cross-border exchange is hugely significant. First, many downtown shops have existed for nearly 100 years primarily because of cross-border shoppers instead of the small U.S. customer bases.[9] Second, the most significant source of gov-

[7] The interlocutor worked across party lines, and interviewees expressed a range of political affiliations and beliefs.

[8] Interview 3, 10/28/2024.

[9] Interview 8, 10/31/2024.

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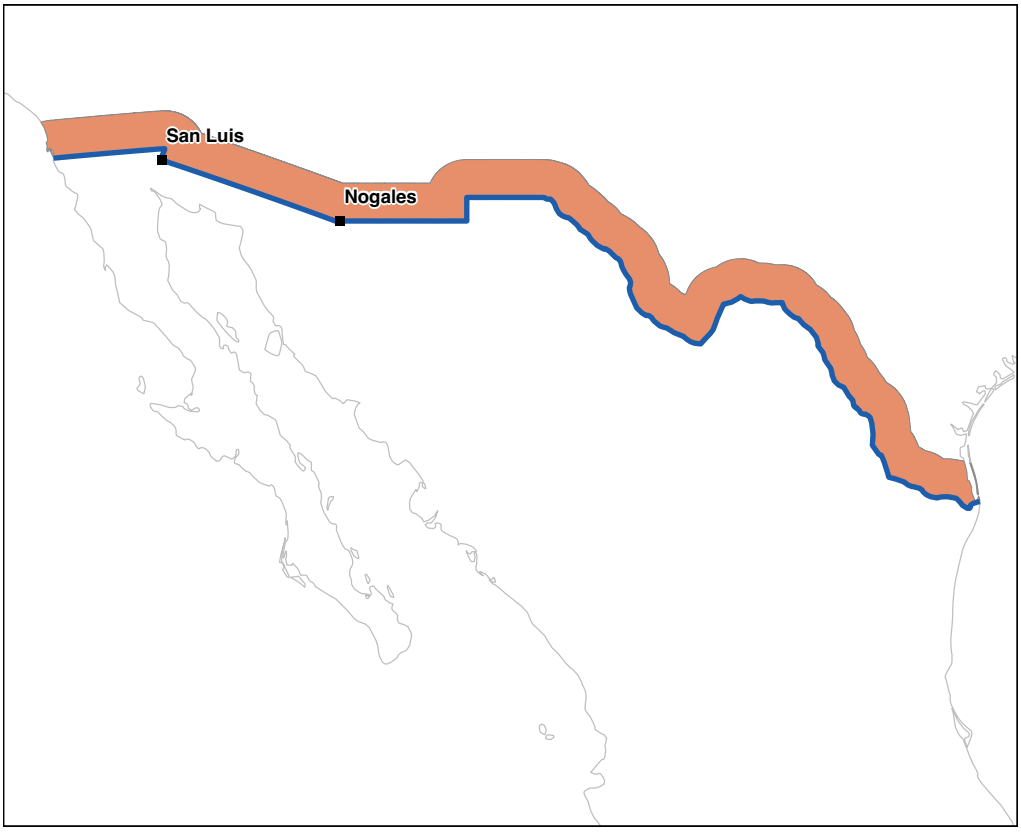


Figure 5 Cases.

ernment revenue for both cities is sales tax generated predominantly by those cross-border shoppers.[10] This revenue is so significant that neither community has historically had a property tax. Finally, international trade through the ports of both communities is tremendous. For example, nearly $29 billion USD in imports and exports traversed Nogales in 2022 (Greater Nogales Santa Cruz County Port Authority 2024). Interviewees consistently referred to trade as critical, saying for example that "All of our existence supports or is related to cross-border trade."[11]

San Luis similarly benefits from cross-border shoppers and trade.[12] But its economy is "entirely dependent" on an agricultural industry whose workforce consists primarily of *campesinos*, or Mexican seasonal and migrant farmworkers.[13] A few thousand people cross over daily throughout the year to work in the region.[14]

Based on these economic dependencies, interviewees repeatedly expressed the sentiment that a community like Nogales "needs the border" to survive[15] and, "If the border wasn't here, you'd have nothing."[16] This idea reflects the unique opportunities that borders can provide to local populations. While the "border effect" identified by economists concerns borders hindering macro-level trade (e.g., Anderson and van Wincoop 2003), the existence of a border simultaneously enables *local* economic exchange that could not exist otherwise. Borderland communities, especially those that are marginalized in the domestic economy, benefit from price differentials at borders (Baud and van Schendel 1997).

In addition to economic exchange, interviewees consistently described a collective social world. As one mayor put it, "We're the same people."[17] Nogales, Arizona, and Nogales, Sonora, in fact, are often described as being part of a broader *Ambos Nogales* ("both Nogales"). Visiting family or friends is a common reason that people cross the border.[18] Interviewees repeatedly referred to "cultural benefits,"[19] "being binational,"[20] "culture and diversity,"[21] being "one community,"[22] a "culture of the border,"[23] and "cultural interconnectedness."[24] Reflecting this sentiment, both communities cooperate with municipalities across the border in a variety of ways, even in the realm of firefighting.[25] Nogales is a sister city of the contiguous Heroica Nogales (Pineda 2017), and San Luis is a sister city of San Luis Río Colorado right across the border as well as of Navolato and Magdalena de Kino further into Mexico (Rodriquez and McClain 2023).

Notably, transnationality has predominated over time. Historically, hundreds of children would enter the U.S. for

[10] Interview 3, 10/28/2024; Interview 9, 11/01/2024; Interview 12, 11/05/2024; and Interview 15, 11/07/2024.
[11] Interview 3, 10/28/2024.
[12] Interview 15, 11/07/2024.
[13] Interview 11, 11/04/2024.
[14] Interview 12, 11/05/2024 and Interview 16, 11/07/2024.
[15] Interview 5, 10/29/2024.
[16] Interview 9, 11/01/2024.
[17] Interview 18, 11/20/2024.
[18] Interview 5, 10/29/2024.
[19] Interview 1, 10/24/2024.
[20] Interview 2, 10/25/2024.
[21] Interview 3, 10/28/2024.
[22] Interview 8, 10/31/2024.
[23] Interview 13, 11/05/2024.
[24] Interview 15, 11/07/2024.
[25] Interview 7, 10/31/2024.

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Halloween and Christmas in Nogales.[26] Both an official and an activist in San Luis recounted their grandparents or parents having once worked as *campesinos*.[27] These accounts of enduring transnationality are reinforced by materials in the local Pimería Alta Historical Society Museum that document years of binational celebrations and collaborations.

Finding 2: Port Authorities and Political Efficacy

Transnational ties in Nogales and San Luis have profoundly shaped prevailing interests concerning border policy. The communities have engaged in decades of activity to demand attention and funding to improve efficiency at ports of entry. This action is exemplified by two organizations: the Greater Nogales Santa Cruz County Port Authority and the Greater Yuma Port Authority.

These port authorities are all-volunteer entities comprised of community political and economic leaders. They interface between local, state, and federal government authorities as well as fellow border communities on both sides about policy and day-to-day management of the ports of entry. Their ultimate mission has been to shorten crossing wait times by improving efficiency via road infrastructure, staffing, and detection technologies. These were repeatedly described as the most important border-related issues for the communities.[28]

However, according to local leaders, federal action on community needs has lacked. Interviewees repeatedly attributed federal neglect or the poor choices made when intervention does occur to physical and political distance.[29] In response, local leaders created the port authorities to support their "forgotten" communities.[30] These activities have included communicating with lawmakers and officials, hiring lobbyists, and applying for grants. Early successes include the $250-million USD renovation of the Nogales-Mariposa Port of Entry in the 2010s and the construction of a new, fully commercial port of entry in San Luis in the late 2000s. According to interviewees, such developments would not have happened without bottom-up drive and collaboration.[31]

These accounts speak to the strained relationships that Nogales and San Luis leaders have had with higher level authorities. They also reflect proactive engagement on border policy, informed by the transnational way of life. Situating the pandemic closure in this historical context, it is especially perplexing that dramatic and immediate resistance against the closure did not emerge.

Finding 3: The Mitigating Effect of Accommodations and Exceptions

Nogales and San Luis are highly transnational and politically efficacious. Why, then, did they not firmly mobilize against the COVID-19 border closure? The hand-coded ACLED event data used earlier did not document any events, and interviewees confirmed the absence of such events while emphasizing that the communities broadly accepted the closure.

The evidence points to the selective nature of the closure. The primary restriction adopted by the U.S. at the border, starting on March 20, 2020, was to differentiate people by citizenship and, in turn, "essential"/"non-essential" status. Citizens could traverse the border as before, but non-citizens could only enter for essential reasons like work, attending school, and cross-border trade (American Immigration Council 2020). Non-citizen entry that was "tourism or recreational," such as shopping and visiting family or friends, was disallowed (Department of Homeland Security 2020). This national policy applied to the entire border with Mexico (and the border with Canada) rather than particular crossings. The motivation articulated by federal officials was to preserve the trade on which the U.S. economy relied (e.g., White House 2020). This closure was repeatedly extended until November 8, 2021, when non-essential travel reopened to fully vaccinated individuals (Federal Register 2021).

Importantly, the exceptions made for trade and workers limited the closure's negative impact. Interviewees consistently reported that these proved critical to the local economies. Put simply by one interviewee, "We didn't slow down on the border."[32]

Economic operations reportedly continued despite the closure. In the words of one mayor, the closure "hardly affected our economy... Trade kept going."[33] A Nogales city official similarly reported that the economic situation remained roughly the same since border industries could still operate.[34] An official in San Luis characterized the category of essential workers as "relatively broad" since it helpfully encompassed agricultural workers.[35] What turned out to be the closure's diminished impact surprised both officials.

Multiple interviewees emphasized that tax revenue remained relatively constant, dipping only temporarily. They variously attributed this outcome to U.S.-side shoppers doing their usual cross-border shopping within the communities, to the permitted non-citizens still crossing, to a financial influx from visiting construction workers, and to citizens shopping on behalf of family and friends in Mexico.[36]

Finding 4: Barriers to Collective Action

Overall, the closure's impact was relatively minimal, making important exceptions for multiple dimensions of the borderland economy. Major tenets of transnationality in this setting were not threatened by the comparatively accommodating closure.

Nevertheless, the closure posed some negative ramifications. For example, while the San Luis ports of entry remained open at all times, the Mexico-side ports limited evening hours. *Campesinos* working in Arizona or California were thus sometimes stranded overnight and forced to sleep outside.[37] Additionally, one interviewee referred to the closure as a "very unnatural" period that harmed social integration.[38]

Clear victims of the closure were downtown stores. The reduced customer base due to the ban on "tourist" travel induced financial strain. For instance, one merchant in Nogales reported that other local businesses eventually had to close.[39] On this front, local leaders did eventually criticize the closure in May–June 2021, more than a year after the policy had been in place. Public letters to the federal government were sent

[26] Interview 2, 10/25/2024.

[27] Interview 16, 11/07/2024 and Interview 18, 11/20/2024.

[28] Interview 3, 10/28/2024; Interview 5, 10/29/2024; Interview 8, 10/31/2024; Interview 9, 11/01/2024; Interview 11, 11/04/2024; Interview 12, 11/05/2024; and Interview 15, 11/07/2024.

[29] Interview 9, 11/01/2024; Interview 13, 11/05/2024; Interview 15, 11/07/2024; and Interview 17, 11/11/2024.

[30] Interview 1, 10/24/2024.

[31] Interview 1, 10/24/2024; Interview 2, 10/25/2024; Interview 3, 10/28/2024; Interview 11, 11/04/2024; Interview 12, 11/05/2024; and Interview 17, 11/11/2024.

[32] Interview 17, 11/11/2024.

[33] Interview 18, 11/20/2024.

[34] Interview 3, 10/28/2024.

[35] Interview 12, 11/05/2024.

[36] Interview 3, 10/28/2024; Interview 12, 11/05/2024; Interview 17, 11/11/2024; and Interview 18, 11/20/2024.

[37] Interview 15, 11/07/2024.

[38] Interview 8, 10/31/2024.

[39] Interview 8, 10/31/2024.

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by the Greater Nogales Santa Cruz County Port Authority, the Santa Cruz County Board of Supervisors, the City of Nogales, and the City of San Luis, and a City of Nogales resolution made the same expression (Chamberlain 2021; Jimenez 2021; Newman 2021; Nogales International 2021). They requested that the federal government permit entry by noncitizen shoppers, stating that the negative impact on downtown storefronts was no longer acceptable since COVID-19 rates had declined.

These statements constituted collective action, but its form precisely reflects the mitigating impact of the closure. The demand narrowly centered downtown storefronts, an important but limited subset of the broader borderland economy; it emerged only a year into the closure's existence and only once COVID-19 rates had declined; and it was a largely symbolic public communication. The negative impact on downtown businesses had been apparent since the outset. But it was not severe and cross-cutting enough to prompt earlier action. Observing the counterfactual is not possible, but action may have emerged sooner and in the starker form of protest had the closure been more restrictive.

Refining the Theory with Selective Bordering

Integrating the findings from these deviant case studies enables a useful refinement of the theory for how local communities react to border hardening. The core logic still holds: transnational communities are broadly vested in policies that facilitate existing cross-border flows. In the face of new hardening, they are also equipped with the opportunity, resources, and grievances to coordinate collective action.

However, the case studies spotlight an important scope condition. For resistance to occur, hardening needs to harm a sufficiently broad swathe of within-community actors involved in contextually relevant transnational flows. The threat's extent depends on which actors and flows a specific policy affects. When targets are scoped, hardening allows key aspects of transnationality to remain intact.

In turn, resistance by transnational communities over border hardening is less likely. First, selective bordering may simply not threaten any contextually relevant interests, precluding any impetus for collective action. Second, selective bordering can undermine collective action by threatening only some interests. The disruption in this case is not extreme enough that political opportunity emerges, that actors are willing to use their resources to organize, and that grievance framings are broadly appealing. In either path, a transnational community facing selective border hardening is less likely to resist. The formal hypothesis summarizing this idea is as follows:

> **Selective Bordering Hypothesis:** *The more selective a border hardening strategy, the less likely transnational communities are to resist it.*

The selective bordering concept, developed inductively with evidence from the U.S.–Mexico borderland, helps to provide a more nuanced understanding of local border politics. However, future analysis deploying evidence from other settings is needed to further specify the concept's implications. Three questions are especially pertinent.

The first question concerns whether the economic dimension of transnationality plays a larger role than the social dimension, as suggested by both the case studies and the quantitative analysis (see Online Appendix 4.2). This might be the case for multiple reasons. First, disruptions to important features of the local economy may pose a broader threat via spillover. Second, this threat could be more universally salient since it relates to people's economic survival. Third, local elites with their own significant stakes in economic exchange may be especially capable of mobilizing resistance. The converse point of these dynamics is that bordering whose selectivity encompasses important pillars of the economy may be sufficient to prevent resistance.

Next, if selective bordering minimizes pushback, why are states not always selective? First, states often simply do not care enough about the preferences of borderland communities to change course. State actors accrue alluring benefits from performing border security for national audiences (Andreas 2010; Linebarger and Braithwaite 2022), which can override the preferences of already marginalized local populations (Idler 2019). Regime type may shape this dynamic, although the quantitative subgroup analysis (see Online Appendix 5.3) did not find that regime type moderated the transnationality–resistance relationship. Second, states cannot be selective at the outset if they do not sufficiently understand local preferences due to uneven state capacity. Although states learn about their populations when expanding territorial control (Blair 2025), this knowledge may be lacking at the outset. Finally, it is worth noting more broadly, selective bordering does not necessarily intend to accommodate local communities. The U.S.'s selective closure, for instance, appears to have been motivated by dyadic trade. Such a fortuitous outcome for transnational communities may be less likely where inter-country dependence is weak.

The final question is whether resistance affects border hardening itself. For a cursory comparison, the hand-coded ACLED data does identify six resistance events in New York state near the border with Canada in mid-2021, a little over a year into the border closure. Media reports about these events, along with criticism by politicians, emphasized the closure's disruption of social ties (News 4 Staff 2021; Staff Reporter 2021). It is not clear, however, that these events caused the closure's end months later in November. This change in policy associated with declining COVID-19 rates, and local resistance in one location is unlikely to have shifted a federal policy for two entire borders. That being said, other cases suggest that more extreme resistance, especially in lower capacity states, might alter border policy. For an example in the hand-coded ACLED data from Kasumbalesa, Democratic Republic of Congo in May 2020, "a group of local people and traders burned tires on the public road and vandalized public buildings... The demonstration was held against the FARDC's new controls at the border, which have halted the normal transit of people and goods due to the coronavirus pandemic... The border was reopened the next day."

Conclusion

States are increasingly endeavoring to display and exert control over borders. Scholars have uncovered important top-down features of this phenomenon, yet the negative reaction of some local communities is largely unexplored. This study advances a framework, centering the borderland as a unique geopolitical space, to explain resistance against border hardening.

Compared to country interiors, communities near borders have the unique opportunity to engage with neighboring society. Transnational ties alter incentives, generating support for policies that sustain prevailing forms of interaction and exchange across the border. In the face of disruptive border hardening, conflict may emerge as transnational communities overcome collective action problems to challenge the state. However, if hardening is selective in its targets and

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thus accommodates major local interests, conflict is less likely to emerge.

I demonstrate that these dynamics transpired over border closures during the COVID-19 pandemic. The global quantitative analysis linked local resistance to transnationality. Deviant case studies of Nogales and San Luis in the U.S. uncovered selective bordering in which the narrow closure undermined collective action.

The empirical focus of this study has been COVID-19 border closures, but the findings speak to border politics more generally. The borderland is a unique geopolitical space that deserves more attention from scholars and policymakers. Distinct processes play out in this setting, with substantial variation characterizing local orientations toward border life and policy. Contestation characterizes the politics of border hardening more than previous work typically recognizes or can explain. Yet, as indicated by the findings about selective bordering, conflict can be averted if the state makes transparent and predictable exceptions for locally salient flows.

This study opens up new areas of inquiry. One natural direction concerns assessing how these dynamics travel across other forms of border hardening. Relatedly, under what conditions do states make accommodations for transnationality? And does resistance impact the "success" of hardening projects? Finally, in a different direction, why do local communities sometimes demand more border hardening? To pursue these questions, the border politics community would benefit from adopting a diverse empirical toolkit. Along with macro-level analyses, data like interviews in borderlands provide granular insight into micro-level processes. Overall, dedicating more theoretical and empirical attention to the politics of borders *within* border spaces will help to broaden knowledge on some of the most pressing issues of our time.

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Supplementary material

Supplementary material is available in the *International Studies Quarterly* data archive.

Data availability

The data underlying this article are available on the ISQ Dataverse, at https://dataverse.harvard.edu/dataverse/isq.

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